

one on Surfshark, only be aware that it will be shared with other, anonymous users. All the important and latest protocols are supported, with old and less secure ones made defunct, so Surfshark really allows users to pick between high speed or reliable connections.

In May 2021, Surfshark published an infrastructure audit by Cure53, a German cybersecurity firm. External audits like these go a long way in boosting consumer confidence. The audit confirmed that Surfshark relied on sound security practices across its wide network.

With 3,299 servers in 65 countries, Surfshark has a pretty wide network, and offers its own DNS servers as well. Surfshark supports unlimited simultaneous connections on a single account, the only other service in our shortlist to do that is IPVanish. There is an app for all the major operating systems, as



well as plugins for the most popular browsers. A large number of payment options are supported, including GPay and UPI. Surfshark is the only VPN on our list that you can purchase through NetBanking. All the major cryptocurrencies are supported, with Surfshark supporting not one, but two crypto payment gateways, CoinGate and CoinPayments. When it comes to availing the service, Surfshark goes a long way in ensuring that users can purchase their services with any method that they find most convenient to use. When it comes

PAYMENT METHODS												
	Bitcoin	Ripple	Ethereum	UPI	Credit Card	Debit Card	Apple Pay	Amazon Pay	GPay	Net Banking	PayTM	PayPal
CyberGhost	Yes	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
ExpressVPN	Yes	No	No	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
IPVanish	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
NordVPN	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	No	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Private Internet Access	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
PrivateVPN	Yes	No	No	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	No	No
PureVPN	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
StrongVPN	No	No	No	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Surfshark	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
VyprVPN	No	No	No	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

to pricing, Surfshark is one of the most economical options around, but not as cheap as say VyprVPN. Still, it is a good deal just because of the support for unlimited simultaneous connections.

Surfshark is a lightweight app, that uses less RAM, with the lowest usage after StrongVPN and IPVanish. When it comes to speedtests, Surfshark performed well across the board, was very good at downloading torrents, but suffered considerably when it came to video streaming. Surfshark uses its proprietary Shadowsocks protocol, which has been built for the

express purpose of bypassing the Great Firewall of China. Note that Surfshark recommends the use of Shadowsocks as only a last resort option for Windows users, as it only provides a tunneling proxy for web browsers. Android users can use the Shadowsocks protocol globally, on all applications though. The protocol is specially designed for users who want high speed connectivity, and only want to bypass restrictions with their web browsers. This is not a general purpose protocol, and there is Wireguard as well as OpenVPN available as the primary choices.

Scoring

All the VPNs that score higher than a 6.5 should be considered good VPNs,

which includes Cyberghost, NordVPN, Private Internet Access and PureVPN, apart from Surfshark. Scoring is pretty straightforward, with points allocated for each of the columns. For the OS, Extensions and protocols, and payment systems it is the number of alternatives supported. The privacy score is derived from five categories, with one point given for not being based in an Eyes country, having a warrant canary, a transparency report, support for split tunneling and the ability to get a static IP address. One of the important features of a VPN is to make sure that there are no DNS leaks or IP leaks, where your IP and location is figured out by the website that you are visiting. All the shortlisted apps passed the tests on dnsleaktest.com and ipleak.net, so these tests are neither scored nor tabulated. Note that here only one service, PrivateVPN does not support split tunneling at all, but points have not been awarded to StrongVPN and IPvanish as well as they only support split tunneling on Android devices. As all the services have a kill switch, none of them got points for that. The points out of five have been doubled to provide a score out of 10. For the speedtests, equal weightage has been given to the speeds in India, and an average of the speeds of all the other servers around the world. All the raw scores have been provided in the tables, so users who prefer privacy over features, or just want to choose the best VPN for streaming, each of the category scores can be weighted to derive your own conclusions of the best VPN service for you.